

3 Textures

Textures bring a model and a scene to life. Without texture, 3D models would appear rather dull and plastic. Textures add colour, reflections, transparency, and roughness to a surface. You can create textures from bitmap files containing photographs, drawings, or paintings and also create textures by using tools to automatically generate textures.

3ds Max uses the Material Editor to create materials, which define the character of the surface. Each material can contain various textures, each defining one aspect of the surface, such as colour, opacity, or roughness. Getting a texture to look the way you want can take a lot of revisions, so understanding how the Material Editor works is critical to mastering texturing within 3ds Max. In the production process, many times you create textures along with the lighting, because light has direct bearing on how a surface will look. Using tools such as Activeshade can also help fine tune textures much more quickly.

3.1 Working with Materials

Materials describe how an object reflects or transmits light, and define what the object will look like. A glass object will have a different material than a wooden one. Within a material, texture maps can be used to define the character of the surface, affecting parameters such as colour, opacity, bump mapping, and reflectivity, among many others.



The simple primitive teapot with a material texture applied

Material Editor

The heart of the texturing process is the Material Editor, which is the dialog box you use to create, alter, and apply the materials in your scene.

- Material menu displays options for getting and putting materials to libraries as well as previewing materials and activating or deactivating materials.
- Navigation menu Displays options for moving to and from parent nodes.
- Options menu Displays options for changing the way materials are displayed and organized.